Balkans shared both the Orthodox Christian tradition and the experience of the Ottoman occupation but the Ottomans also occupied parts of Catholic Hungary, Croatia and Bosnia. (The reason why Medjugorje, the world-famous pilgrim site in the ethnic-Croatian part of Bosnia and Herzegovina, called Herzegovina, is managed by the Franciscan order is that they were the only Catholic clergy allowed to operate by the Ottomans.) As a result, the Balkans is where the Western (Catholic), Eastern-Orthodox and Oriental-Muslim traditions meet. They form the true multicultural region of Europe and they were like that long before modern Turks, Moroccans, Algerians and other Muslims set foot in Western Europe. They are the true and probably only true home of European Islam – something we should not forget when talking about integrating Muslim immigrants into European society.

Another important thing to note about the Balkans is that, while the concept of 'Eastern Europe' includes Central Europe and 'Eastern Europe proper', the war in former Yugoslavia has resulted in the Balkans somehow being excluded from it. Indeed, in the late 1980s and early 1990s, Yugoslavia was rarely mentioned in the context of democratic transition, but almost exclusively with relation to the war there, which many saw as a civil and ethnic strife. The rise of Serbian nationalism under Milošević (with some help from the Croatian nationalism of Franjo Tudjman, although the two cannot be compared exactly) resulted in the somewhat surprising fact that Yugoslavia, once the most progressive part of the former Communist world, began to lag seriously behind the rest of the Communist world in terms of democratic development. More than thirty years later this still has practical consequences in terms of the delay on their way to the EU too.

Not only Milošević but also the Serbian Academy of Science and the overwhelming majority of the Serbian public entirely missed the point about what was happening in the late 1980s. While rightly concerned that Yugoslavia was going to fall apart and fearing that this would eventually result in ethnic communities of Serbs scattered across Yugoslavia and no longer living in one single state (something that the Serbs had achieved with the creation of the Yugoslav Kingdom at the end of World War I), they decided to prevent that by the use of the (federal) army over which they had control. It was a tragic mistake for everyone in Yugoslavia but –